Where black is the reigning colour

Black, beautiful and dramatic, is the reigning colour at the "Vishwakarma 90," an exhibition of metal crafts by National award winning craftsmen organised by the Crafts Council of India and the Office of the Development Commissioner of Handicrafts.

And when black and silver are complemented and contrasted with each other, they produce a splendid effect, as in the Bidriware fashioned by master craftsman Shah Rasheed Ahmed Quadri.

Each unwavering silver line is inlaid on the black metal with machine-line precision, each geometrical or floral motif is executed with as much symmetry as its immediate neighbour, and each design with an unfailing perspective of the space available and the purpose of the article. Flower vases, slender bangles, eardrops and boxes are exquisitely appealing and all designs are executed free hand.

Of Persian ancestry, this beautiful work using an alloy of copper and zinc is now confined to Bidar in Karnataka. For Shah Rasheed Ahmed Quadri, the recipient of the National award in 1988 and the Karnataka State award in 1984, it is a heriditary craft spanning generations.

The exhibition in the Vishwakarma series is a homage to Kamaladevi Chattopadhyaya.

If Bidriware is an example of the sophisticated Muslim contribution to our heritage, the iron figures of animals crafted by Sonadhar Viswakarma of Bastar district, Madhya Pradesh are simple and yet striking and have primitive and tribal origins harking back to a past when the discovery of iron went hand in hand with hunting.

"Many more artisans were to have participated in the exhibition — craftsmen working in copper from Almora, U.P., in art metalware from Delhi, "Dhokra" (Assam) Tarkashi (wire inlay) and Meenakari from Delhi. But due to the stoppage of trains, they could not come," says Ms. Seetha Narayanaswamy of Crafts Council.

The exhibition is on till November 1, 10 a.m. to 7 p.m. at the crafts council premises, 6, Kasturi estates. — **K.S.**

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